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Roy McCurdy

Drummer Roy McCurdy has worked in a variety of jazz settings. A native of Rochester, NY, he first recorded with the Jazz Brothers, a group co-led by Chuck and Gap Mangione. In the early 60's he drove the combos of Sonny Rollins, Bobby Timmons and Betty Carter. Cannonball Adderley called on Roy in 1965 and for the next ten years he was part of one of the hottest groups in jazz. Cannon's biggest hits were recorded during this time, including "Mercy, Mercy" and "Country Preacher." In the latter 70's, Roy worked with vocalist Kenny Rankin, and found work in the studios of Los Angeles. He began a long relationship with Nancy Wilson and currently tours here and abroad with her.

Roy was interviewed by Monk Rowe in New York on November 16, 1995.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive here in New York City. My name is Monk Rowe, and we're very pleased to have with us jazz drummer Roy McCurdy. Welcome.

RM: Oh, thank you.

MR: Thanks for coming, and I know you've been traveling quite a bit lately. Can you bring us up to date on what you're doing with your career right now?

RM: Well right now, well I'm still working with Nancy Wilson. You know I've been doing her, working with Nancy for sixteen years. So I'm still doing that. We're just getting ready to do a concert tonight. We just came from Boston actually four days ago, and I just stayed up there and spent some time with my wife. She's up there doing a movie. And I just came in this morning.

MR: And where do you go from here?

RM: We have a concert tomorrow at Toledo, Ohio, and then Saturday we'll be back in Los Angeles.

MR: Now you're from Rochester is that right?

RM: Yeah, originally.

MR: Rochester has been, over the years, a pretty good town for music, I think especially when you came up. There are some great drummers that came out of Rochester. Vinnie Ruggerio and yourself and later Steve Gadd.

RM: Right. I used to, you know, we used to play in Rochester at a place called The Pythod, well and several other places too. But I remember when Steve's father used to bring him in by the hand and let him play. He was a little guy like this you know. And he'd sit in and play and he sounded great then too. And Vinnie actually was from Massapequa, Long Island. And he came in later, after I left. But I knew Vinnie in New York and he played great then at the time.

MR: I think his son is playing now too.

RM: Yeah, yeah. So he's one of those guys that was on the tour that we did. I think he was with Joe Romano.

MR: How did you get hooked up with the Jazz Brothers?

RM: Chuck and Gap [Mangione]. Well after I came out of the service, you know I went into the Air Force and then I came back and I was studying at the Eastman School of Music with Bill Street, a percussion teacher there. And I started working at a place called The Pythod which was a local jazz club up there. And they had a lot of people coming through. And Chuck and Gap were local musicians and I think Chuck had the band. He was leading one of the local bands and working in this club. So I think shortly after I got home out of the Air Force, the drummer who was working there had left or something happened to him. And a couple of days later I just went in and played the gig. And we became friends. Actually I had known Chuck for a long time before I went into the service. But I started working that gig and we became friends. It was almost like family you know. His father had the Italian grocery store and the food and all that kind of stuff.

MR: Didn't he always invite the visiting musicians to Rochester over to his house?

RM: All the time.

MR: Gillespie and —

RM: Oh, yeah, yeah. And they would go in to the store and his mother would just put the pots on and everybody would eat. Well we'd play. And we'd stay over there and we'd play and everything. And then we, the group came, kind of worked together a lot and then we made a record. I think what happened is Nat Adderley I think heard about us. And Cannon had a series called "Cannonball Adderley Presents" at that time, from Riverside Records. And he signed us for Riverside and we did our first album.

MR: It's interesting that years later — but we'll get to that.

RM: Right. And I remember they came up to, not — I don't think it was Cannon — but I think Nat came up to The Pythod and sat in the audience and listened to the band you know. And what happened from that is we wound up going to New York to play at the old Five Spot. There was two Five Spots at the time. The old one was in the Bowery and they it moved up around Sixth Avenue.

MR: About what year was this?

RM: Probably, this was 1959, almost '60.

MR: Rock 'n Roll was kind of in its infancy — well it'd been around for a few years, but you were into the jazz.

RM: Yeah. I was strictly into jazz at that time. Yeah. That's all I wanted to do. I knew that was what I was going to do. I had made up my mind that's what I was going to do. And well actually that's how we met Chuck and we just, they, we went on the road and did little

things with the band and traveled around all through the Upstate New York area, in the wintertime too, in the cold trailers. It was incredible. We had a couple of good musicians too that came on the band. Jimmy Garrison played with us for a while, Steve Davis played bass with us for a while. So it was great, it was nice.

MR: When you got through the Jazz Brothers time, other things opened up for you. Betty Carter a few years later?

RM: No, what happened is we went to the Five Spot and played with the Brothers, and then I came back to Rochester and we went back into The Pythod. And I got a telegram from Benny Golson. And he said he wanted me to come to New York and join the Jazztet. And Tootie Heath was the drummer with the 'tet then, and Tootie was leaving. So, great, I says, that's fantastic. So it was about a week or so before I had to join them. And so they threw me a big party and everything at The Pythod. And I told everybody I was going to New York. I left and went to New York, and the rehearsal and the first job was in Birdland. And they put me up in the Alvin Hotel. It used to be the Elvin Hotel was across the street where all the musicians, and you know, everybody stayed there. So the rehearsal was that afternoon. And I went over to rehearsal and I got there and there was about six other drummers standing out there. And it turned out to be an audition, you know? And I said, hey, wait a minute!

MR: Well that wasn't the normal way of doing things was it?

RM: Well I don't know. I thought I had the job. I told everybody I had left home, you know.

MR: You couldn't go back if you didn't get it.

RM: I couldn't go back. Party cake, I mean, everything. So—

MR: Well you certainly had an incentive to do good.

RM: So we went into Birdland and the first thing Benny said to me, he saw me coming across the street, he says "ah, here comes the Rochester Flash." But we went down into Birdland and we, everybody got a chance to play and run over the music and run through all those pretty tunes that Benny wrote. And they went in the back and they came out later and said "you got the job."

MR: Thank you.

RM: Yeah, right. And that night was my first gig, that very same night.

MR: Who else was on the band at that time?

RM: Harold Mabern was the piano player. The bass player was a Tommy Williams — I don't know if you know Tommy Williams — he was a wonderful, wonderful bass player. And he wound up, he was driving a taxi cab in New York a lot, you know, instead of playing steady. But he just played so great. Tommy Williams, myself, Grachan Moncur III, the trombone player, and that was it, and Art and Benny and myself.

MR: Did that band record?

RM: Yeah, we did. We did about three albums together at that time. It was great.

MR: What was recording like then as compared to now?

RM: Well then it was much faster. I mean we would go into the studio here in New York and we'd knock out an album in three, maybe four hours. And that was it, you know. Everything was like one or two takes.

MR: But this was material that you were performing out.

RM: Yeah. Even when we played with guys that we didn't play with all the time, it was just the same way. At that time it was really incredible. You'd go out and do an album and it was three hours, four hours later you were finished you know. It wasn't until years later that I went in the studio and did an album that took forever you know — that they took a long time on you know.

MR: Was that a more of a Pop type?

RM: It was with Blood, Sweat and Tears. And it took about six months. It went from city to city. Every place we went we went into a studio and recorded.

MR: And not — the whole band wouldn't be there, right? It might be just you and the bass player or something.

RM: Oh, it would be the whole band.

MR: No kidding?

RM: Because the whole band would be traveling together.

MR: But I mean when you were recording, did you do it all at once?

RM: Yeah. We started out, Bobby Columby had a studio here outside of New York in a home of his. And he had different rooms in the studio and different people in the band would be in different rooms. And you were connected by video camera. But that album took a long time to do.

MR: Was that a different situation for you — Blood Sweat and Tears — that didn't come up before?

RM: Yeah. It was, well you know we had been playing like with Cannonball like a little funk and stuff like that, we had been playing several types of music. So when Cannon passed, I started working with Kenny Rankin. And then we were in San Francisco and they called. But you know I was kind of ready for that because I had been playing a lot of that different type of music and stuff.

MR: How did the thing with the Adderleys come about? Did you step in after, was it Louie Hayes?

RM: Yeah. Well what had happened was I was in New York for a while, and I had played with the 'tet and I'd played with Betty Carter and I had played with Mitchell and Ruff and Sonny Rollins. I had been with Sonny for quite a while. And then in 1960, no 63, I went back home. I was married, in my first marriage, and I was trying to save this marriage,

and I went back to Rochester. And I took a job and I just stopped playing. I took a job at Eastman Kodak as a film tester.

MR: I think half of Rochester worked at Eastman, and the other ones at Xerox.

RM: Yeah. I was working in the dark and I had these big rolls of film, and listening to the jazz on the radio, hearing myself on albums and stuff.

MR: Was that the Harry Abraham show?

RM: Yeah. Actually, Harry Abraham, but at that time it was called Will Moyle.

MR: Yeah. And you're listening to yourself.

RM: And I'm saying what am I doing here you know, in this place. And so it was about, I had been there almost a year and I got several calls, I mean Horace wanted me to come out and a couple of the other guys wanted me to come. And then this big chance came with Cannon. Louis Hayes was leaving to go with Oscar Peterson, and Cannon called and he said, I think his exact words were "Fool — I want you to come join my band." So I said oh, man, what am I going to do about this? You know I was really tired of Kodak and so I talked to my wife and I told her that I was thinking about going. But I talked to the guys, the guys on the block that I grew up with and I told them. And they said if you don't go, we're going to — you'd better go. Because you know they'd been proud, I'd been playing with all these guys and we had grown up together and they knew it. So I told her "Listen, I'm going to go to New York" and I just went, and I joined Cannon. And it was great.

MR: Ten years, right?

RM: Twelve, almost twelve.

MR: Twelve years.

RM: It took me about almost a month before my playing chops were back together, but he was very patient and it was great. And finally it just clicked and we had a good relationship.

MR: Some classic albums. I wanted to ask you about a couple that I think really stand out. One was with Nancy — that was before you — but the one I'm thinking —

RM: The second one.

MR: Yeah.

RM: That was one we were doing for Capitol Records in Los Angeles. We were doing a live recording. What they used to do at Capitol is they used to take the big studio, I think it was A studio, it's huge. And they'd make it into a night club. They'd put a bar in there, drinks, and they'd call people and tell them Cannon's recording. Well I mean, by the time we did our third album I mean there was hundreds, I mean there was just a crowd outside the Capitol Records, you know, trying to get in for this thing. But we were recording and Nancy was in the audience and Lou Rawls was in the audience. And Cannon called them both up to just spontaneously do some things. And they came up and did it.

MR: They sure did. There was some very great piano players too, with the band of course. When tunes like "Mercy, Mercy" and stuff, when — you would read them in rehearsal, did you get a sense of — this tune is going to sell a lot of records?

RM: Yeah. You know, we were always, well we were hoping, we were always experimenting. That band was experimenting all the time. And we played straight ahead jazz, we played all kinds of stuff. So when Joe brought that tune in, Zawinul, to, I think we were rehearsing in Teaneck, New Jersey. We rehearsed in Nat Adderley's basement out there.

MR: Is that from the song Teaneck he wrote?

RM: Yeah I guess it is. And I lived out there too, I moved out there eventually. But a lot of musicians were in that area in Teaneck. But when he brought that tune in he says "listen to this," and he started playing it. And we were just starting to get into the electronics you know, where we were using electric piano. And we had a Wurlitzer that we wanted to use. And he played this tune and we says, "yeah, let's try it." We rehearsed it and got it together. We went and tried it and people loved it. They loved it you know? There was a lot of things — Joe was amazing because he heard a lot of different things way before things like electronic things, like bending notes and all that kind of thing. He used to shake the piano to bend the notes I mean. And he had these little things, gadgets. And finally all these things would come in you know. We went from the Wurlitzer to the Rhodes.

MR: And there is a specific album — "Country Preacher" — and there's a tune on that, the title tune on that thing. And the most amazing thing happens. This was a live thing with Operation Bread Basket or something? Jesse Jackson?

RM: The Country Preacher.

MR: And you play this tune and there is, in the middle of the song, it builds and builds, and then it shuts off, and then the piano comes back in. And the crowd—

RM: Yeah they loved that.

MR: Goes nuts!

RM: That pause.

MR: I just had — what was that, I mean I get chills listening to that. I can't imagine what it was like to be there.

RM: It was just a pause we had where we had this space with this tension in it. And you know I don't know did you ever see Cannon and Nat live?

MR: Oh, yeah.

RM: They were really funny to me, because I was behind them all the time, looking at them. And this brother was short and Cannon was tall. And they had a way of snapping their fingers and moving, and their behinds were both in sync you know. And they would be snapping and the behinds would be in sync. And during that pause, that's what was going

on, you know they had that little sync thing going. And then they'd go back and hit it. Joe would hit it, and the people loved that thing. It was a kind of a follow up to "Mercy, Mercy." Yeah it was really nice.

MR: It's almost as if you guys were creating a style as you went along.

RM: Yeah. It was.

MR: Did you have a name for it or did you let other people name it?

RM: We just let other people name it. We just called it — it was just music for us you know. We didn't want to be in one particular slot all the time, like just straight ahead jazz or something. We wanted to be able to do all kinds of things and have some fun. And not only did we do different like Funk and Soul and Gospel and Jazz, we also experimented with different time figures and things too at that time. Like seven-four time, five-four time and things like that, which were, we did "Seventy Four Miles Away" that album was seven-four time. And then George Duke came up with a tune in five-four that we did, it was great. He was one of the wonderful piano players that came through, Joe Zawinul, George Duke, Hal Galper, and then there was Mike Wolff came on the band, I don't know if you know Mike. He was the musical director for the Arsenio Hall show. But he was our last piano player. Larry Willis was on the band for a while.

MR: And he was with Blood, Sweat and Tears too wasn't he, later on?

RM: Yeah. Larry was, actually I think Larry recommended me for the job, because he was on there before me.

MR: That one record you did, "Black Messiah" I think it was, there was some interesting stuff on that too. Music from that, didn't they write a Broadway show? Called John Henry or something?

RM: Yeah. But that was an album on a show we were working on called "Big Man" which was like about John Henry. And Cannon and Nat had written all the music for that. We recorded it actually. But before we could get the show off the ground, he passed away. Yeah, it was beautiful.

MR: What's the road like for your aspiring musicians, being on the road? Good and bad?

RM: Sure it is. I really don't know about the young guys today, what the road is like. I can tell you what it's like for me.

MR: But in those days.

RM: Oh you mean in those days. It was fun. It was exciting. To me it was anyway. When I first went out with the Jazztet and people like that, I mean this wasn't too much fun, but we would jump in cars and station wagons and we'd travel all over the country. Also, when I joined Cannonball at first we were doing that before we started flying. But once we got in town and started playing and got to these different places, I mean we had a great time. You know I did because I was learning all the time and meeting people all the

time and learning how to play my instrument and things like that. So it was great. I never got tired of it. It wasn't like being on the road in a bus—

MR: With a big band

RM: With a big band, you know there was just a few of us. And we only did the cars for a while, and then we started flying everyplace, so it was good. It wasn't bad.

MR: Did you ever have an opportunity to play behind Joe Williams?

RM: Sure. I love Joe. We did an album with Cannon and Joe, a live record for Fantasy Records I believe it was.

MR: He did some nasty Blues on that record.

RM: But I've worked with Joe several times and I really love him, I love the way he sings and he lays it down so he's a hard swinger so he's perfect for the drums. Betty Carter was like that too.

MR: She's really I think one of the truest of jazz singers.

RM: Yeah, she could sing. We used to work together a long time ago with Harold Mabern and Bob Cranshaw.

MR: You just missed Bob. He said hello.

RM: Yeah, that's my man. With Bob and Harold, and then there was I think Ron Carter did it for a while and myself. As a matter of fact Betty — the first time I went to Japan, Betty was on that tour with Sonny Rollins. It was Sonny's quartet and Betty was singing in it.

MR: And what about overseas? You've been overseas?

RM: Yeah. I loved Europe. They really liked the music so much, especially in the 60's and 70's, the jazz was just so big. And we did a lot of playing over there. I lived and I stayed in Paris for a while and lived over there for a little while playing with Martial Solal, the piano player. I had a good time with him. Dee Pederson. He couldn't speak no language, but we were over there playing and running around.

MR: Wow. So the music just kind of took care of that?

RM: Yeah. The music took care of that. And I traveled through a lot of the countries, I mean all the Scandinavian countries and places like that, Germany, all those European countries. Then over to the Orient. In Japan the music is still incredible. It's their first music, jazz you know.

MR: Bob said he just got back from there with Sonny Rollins.

RM: Yeah. It's incredible. I was just telling somebody the other day I was, we just got back from there not too long ago too. And we were in Keio Plaza in Tokyo. And when you go out to your hotel, all the music is piped in the hotels, and it's all hard jazz, straight ahead jazz. But it wasn't nothing on the radio. I used to have to come in the hall to listen. In the hallway, man it was incredible. I mean you're hearing Joe Henderson and all those people

out there, when you're waiting for the elevators, and in the department stores it's the same thing.

MR: What's the traditional Japanese music that they have? I mean they have their own Rock 'n Roll or Pop music?

RM: Well I'm sure they do.

MR: You didn't have the opportunity to hear it?

RM: Yeah. But you know they got all that from us though. When we first went over there they were listening to us to get all that stuff. When we used to go to Japan, you'd pull up in the airport and it'd be like there'd be like three or four hundred people waiting outside with signs and things, welcoming you to Japan. In the lobby, just like Rock 'n Roll. And the musicians were all with you all the time. They were learning the music. Now they have very wonderful musicians you know. But they got it all from us. But they're playing wonderful. They've got great musicians of all kinds of music, Rock, Jazz — whatever it is, they get on to it very fast.

MR: Tell us about some of your experiences with studio work on the west coast.

RM: The studio? Well I haven't done too many shows and things like that. Most of the things I do in the studio on the west coast are recordings. I go in and do recordings, and that's just like all recordings, we go in and do those and they're fun and we do it with a lot of different people and things. Actually you know when I first went to California, when I moved out there, I moved out there because Cannonball had a show. And it was a variety show, the same kind of show as Johnny Carson. Did you know that?

MR: Cannonball did?

RM: Sure. And it was on NBC. And it came on after the Johnny Carson show. He had the same kind of guests. He had a co-host which was a lady. He sat behind a desk and everything. And he did all kinds of things, from playing to dancing to —

MR: I can't believe this.

RM: Oh, it was incredible. That's why we went there because we went out to do this show, to be with the band you see. And I was just talking to somebody not too long ago, we'd love to get out, to see some of those tapes from the old shows.

MR: I guess so.

RM: And then, after Cannon left — it went on for almost a year — and after he left it became like, I think Nancy had that show. It became The Nancy Wilson Show or something like that. And then Lou Rawls had it, it came and went to Lou Rawls. But it was a wonderful, wonderful show.

MR: Well he had that gift of—

RM: He could talk to anybody. He had all the same people, I mean all the actors and musicians and people like that were his guests and things. And he would interview them with his co-host. He had a band. It was great. It was the same thing.

MR: Your group visited colleges quite often too, didn't they?

RM: Yeah. Well that's what we were doing in '70, well actually we started around '73. By '75, just before Cannon passed, we were doing a lot of colleges, doing clinics, doing concerts. We'd go and do a clinic one day and we'd go and work with the different instruments, and then we'd do a concert the next day. And we'd talk to people in assemblies about jazz. The history of jazz, about jazz, and things. Now that's strange. Coming from behind your instrument, to give a speech about music. I mean you're never nervous. I was never nervous playing drums. But you come from behind those drums and start talking, that's something else. You know the podium, and you look and there's all these folks staring at you.

MR: Well you say "well here's what I do."

RM: Yeah. The first time I ever did it, Joe Zawinul teases me about this today, Nat too. Because I kind of swore the first time. And they were talking and Cannon was giving his thing, which he could really talk I mean he could really talk good. Then Nat would do his thing. And they said "well McCurdy, tell them something about when you first came up to be a drummer." And I said "well," and I went to the podium and I was, you know, hip, and I said "well shit." And they all just fell out — and they tease me about that today. They say, you know, I haven't lived that down.

MR: I'll bet people were paying attention after that, anyway.

RM: You know I was talking like I talk in the street you know. And they all cracked up. The audience cracked up and everything you know. Which was cool, you know, because it helped me to relax.

MR: Can we get him at the school, Mike? Recreate that scene?

RM: Have you talked to Joe or anybody like that? To Zawinul?

MR: No, I'd love to.

RM: Yeah. He lives in town here. But he still talks about, he'll tell you, he'll really elaborate.

MR: Well Nat, just to mention, had told us some great stories about some of the songs he wrote, and how they all had things behind them, they weren't just contrived. He played from his experience. That's what I think was so great about Cannonball's group is you had some different influences happening. You know you had a piano player from Austria to put a different take on some of the music.

RM: Right. And different feelings. And different kind of time signatures and things. Because you know Joe used to play —

MR: Accordion?

RM: Accordion, like in polka bands and things like that. So he used to talk about that and how he could relate that to jazz, and all those kind of different things like that. And I'm sure Nat was right I mean they wrote a lot of things that had a lot to do with their background, like the Gospel things we did, I'm sure it was a big part of their Florida background, and things like that. And Cannon. I'm sure. I never heard them talk about it but I guess it was.

MR: Was your family musical?

RM: Well my father played a little piano, but just for himself. And my mother did too. And they just did it at home. But no, my father was a caterer. But my sister supported me for music, and she bought me my first instrument and stuff like that. My cousin used to play like drums in the Elks marching band and I used to see those drums. But music was around the house all the time. I mean records were playing all the time, so we always heard the music, so I was around it all the time, to listen to it.

MR: And you've been with Nancy for what, you said sixteen years?

RM: Yeah, about sixteen years now. Long time.

MR: I wish someone could make up a chart about how musicians have moved from one group to the other. I mean you mentioned Bob Cranshaw and he played with Sonny Rollins, and you played with Sonny Rollins, and it gets very complicated, but word gets out who's good.

RM: Oh, yeah. And everybody moves into the, yeah, it kind of intertwines. Even when you're playing with local people, if you're playing out in Los Angeles around local things, people, it seems to be the same musicians playing with different groups all the time. It's really kind of interchanging all the time.

MR: Is there a difference in, these days, in the feel of jazz on the west coast and in New York?

RM: Oh, yeah, I think so. Music is still played hard here. They did it hard, they play hard, you know there's a lot of fire. And when I tend to play out there I usually play a little lighter than I would usually. When I come back here, I naturally dig in because it's the way the guys play back here. I think so, yeah. I think the feeling is a little different. The music is good on both sides, but I think the feeling of playing it is a little bit different.

MR: Who do you listen to these days? Who do you like?

RM: You know I like a lot of the young guys that are playing. A lot of the young drummers are really good drummers out there. Carl Allen I love Carl the way he plays; I love Gregory Hutchinson; Herlin Riley; all those guys, they play so good. You know and all the guys that they play with, I try to keep up with all that, and listen to it. But I listen to all the good guys.

MR: What about styles of music, is there anything happening now that you react to one way or the other?

RM: Not really, I don't think so. I still love jazz first. But I listen to and try to keep up with all kinds of music because I have to play all kinds of music in different situations a lot of times. So I try to keep on top of all that you know. But if I sit down or go into a store to buy some music, I'm going to the jazz section first. That's my love.

MR: When you were getting into drums, who were the first people that really grabbed you back then?

RM: When I first, when I first started listening I was listening to probably Shelly Manne. Shelly, guys like that, and then a friend of mine turned me on, well actually we were listening to a lot of west coast music at that time because we were listening to Kenton and we were listening to you know Bob Cooper and all those kind of groups like that, Pete Jolly, all those kind of people. And then a friend of mine came over with an Art Blakey album, "The Jazz Messenger" one of the twelve-inch things you know? It was done at Birdland actually. And I said whoa. And then I started listening to Art. And I was listening to Max back then too I must say, and Joe Jones and people like that, Kenny Clarke. Those were all guys that I was listening to all the time. All those kinds of guys I was listening to constantly. Buying records. Anything they were on I was getting them.

MR: Well I'd like to say that you were on some of the records that made me go "oh, wow!"

RM: Is that right? Oh that's great. But I'll tell you I always wanted to do this you know. And when I was in the service, sitting in Alaska in the barracks, in Fairbanks, and it was 50 below zero outside, and we'd have the records on and we'd play jazz all the time.

MR: That will keep you warm.

RM: Yeah, and I said I wonder if anyone will ever let me play with these guys, you know? So it was great for me too to get up and finally be able to do that.

MR: So you didn't have a musical experience in the service. Like some guys actually made out pretty well.

RM: Well I did, yeah. That's what I did in the service. I was in the Special Services, I was in the band. And we traveled around and we did shows all the time. And we traveled all through that northern area where it was freezing. And we did all these elaborate shows, stage shows and things. And then we had a big jazz band, a big band jazz band and we had a small group jazz band. And in Fairbanks they had, Fairbanks at that time was like the Wild West you know? It was 1956 and it was a territory then, it hadn't even turned statehood. And all the gangsters, everybody was up there, because they could get away you know. They would run away from the states and they wouldn't be brought back because it hadn't turned statehood. As soon as it turned statehood they all had to cut out. But they had clubs, it was just full of clubs and things. There was two or three jazz clubs and we used to work like six nights a week in these jazz clubs.

MR: It's funny that jazz has seemed to have been helped by corruption.

RM: Isn't that something, yeah?

MR: Because you had Kansas City with that whole era there, and you had Chicago in Capone's era, and Milt Hinton talks about how much work there was at that point. Now you're telling us in Alaska.

RM: Oh, yeah. In Alaska there must have been about three, maybe four clubs that had jazz full time. And they were always packed. We played there and when we finished with our duties in the Air Force, I'd go pack up and go into town to play. I'd get home about two in the morning and go back to what I was doing. Yeah. I met a piano player up there. He was out of Baltimore, out of New York actually. His name was Roger Fleming. One of the greatest piano players I had ever heard. And I lost track, I never knew what happened to him. But he played like in the Wynton Kelly mode and he was just incredible. I thought for sure he was going to be a huge, huge star you know. And when I left there, that was it, I never found him again. But they had those kind of players up there.

MR: How long were you, a couple of years in the service?

RM: I was supposed to be in for four years. I got out in three and a half. They had this early out thing so—

MR: I'll take it.

RM: I'll take it. So I got out. It was great.

MR: Any recordings coming up in the near future for you?

RM: What have we done? I haven't done anything in a while because we've been so busy traveling with Nancy and things. I think she's getting ready to go in the studio, I'm not sure if I'm going to do anything with that or not. But she's getting ready to do some things.

MR: What kind of situation do you like to record in? Do you like to do it mostly live? Is that how you've done most of your recording?

RM: Mostly everything has been live, but there's been some things where we just go in and put the rhythm tracks down and they come in and do some other things afterwards. But most of the things have been live. I like it like that. I like to hear everything together, to see what it's going to be.

MR: You feel more connected to everybody I would imagine.

RM: Yeah, I think so. We did this, I think it was about a year and a half ago, we did this Scott Hamilton thing. It was just beautiful. They brought all the strings in the studio and the rhythm section and it was just beautiful. It came out great. I don't know if you heard that Scott Hamilton with strings.

MR: Yeah. In fact he was just at our college.

RM: Was he, yeah. We had a good time with that. It was all live. Usually they'll bring the rhythm section in and then bring the strings in another time. But this time it was all together. It was great.

MR: And that Kenny Rankin thing must have been kind of a change.

RM: Oh yeah, I forgot, we just did that. We just finished that, yeah. Well Kenny's beautiful. I love the way he sings. And he decided to get away from, not play that much guitar on this album and he got myself and Mike Wofford and Brian Bromberg and he just stood up and sang on this album, it was great. As a matter of fact we went out and did a few dates like that. He's beautiful.

MR: He does have a unique sounding voice.

RM: Yeah. He's a wonderful musician. I've done about four or five albums with him with Don Costa and strings and different things like that. I love Kenny, he's a beautiful guy. He's sort of a cult figure.

MR: Yeah. Any words of wisdom or experience to young musicians coming out today?

RM: Well you know I just can tell them what the guys used to tell me is just to listen to everything that you can get your hands on. Listen to all different types of music. And you know play as much as you can. And for me, I'm a gym guy so I like to be in the gym a lot. So I think that's really helped me over the years, for being strong and for playing and for being on the road and keeping healthy. You know I don't drink or smoke or anything like that, so that's, the physical thing in the gym has really been a big part of helping me survive.

MR: I think it works. I told you you didn't look much different on this record, and you said this was almost thirty years ago.

RM: Yeah. Well Nancy and I are getting ready to hit our big one next year, we're both going to turn 60 you know. So I'm about four months older than she is. She likes to tell me that you know. But I'm going to have a great, we're going to have a big party next year.

MR: Well this has really been a pleasure for us.

RM: It's fun. I hope I told you some good things.

MR: Yeah, you did. And I hope we can get to hear you play tonight, too.

RM: Yeah, yeah. Well I don't think it should be any problem. We should be able to do that.

MR: All right. On behalf of Hamilton College, I'd like to thank Roy McCurdy for sharing his experiences with us. And have a good gig.

RM: Thank you, I really loved it.